

Sop Opera

- Scholarship for girls in Class XI and XII who score above 70 per cent.
Rs 22 crore*
 - Scholarships for students pursuing professional courses.
Rs 30 crore
 - Funds to minority community-run colleges.
Rs 36 crore
 - Revamp of 80 graveyards with walls, roads and beautification
Rs 12 crore
 - Vocational training classes for girls.
Rs 25 crore
 - Loans to entrepreneurs.
Rs 42 crore
 - Funds to women's self-help groups.
Rs 5 crore
- * amount allocated by the Government*

(LEFT) EX-CHIEF MINISTER VILASRAO DESHMUKH WITH MUSLIM LEADERS;
(BELOW LEFT) THE ULEMA COUNCIL MEETS; CHIEF MINISTER ASHOK CHAVAN

ing the Lok Sabha elections. While the Congress fielded a reluctant A.R. Antulay from Raigad, the NCP, as a quick-fix measure, put up Azam Pansare from Maval. Both lost. Says Mufti Mohammed Ismail, activist and president of the Jamiat-e-Ulema, Malegaon, "The parties deliberately put up these candidates in seats where they were sure to lose. If the parties were serious, they would have fielded them from constituencies which have a sizeable Muslim population."

Pleased with these measures, Naseem Siddiqui, chairman of the Minorities Commission, says, "The Sachar Committee report states that the condition of Muslims is worse than the Dalits. So, special measures are needed for their upliftment." Muslim activists believe that the government has for long neglected the interests of the minorities. Demands such as judicial powers for the Minorities Commission and handing over the Haj House to the community have been lying in

February 2008, the state had allotted Rs 167 crore to the MDD, out of which only Rs 50 crore had been used till December 2008. Says an official from the department: "The funds were only allotted on paper and not earmarked. Since no scheme was cleared, money could not be disbursed."

Then there is the problem of the efficacy of projects. NGOs working with Muslims believe that some of the sops are hare-brained schemes which will not show any benefits. For instance, girls who score a first division at the Class X exams will be given a scholarship for junior college studies and those pursuing professional courses will be given a fee waiver up to Rs 40,000. "In a community where only 25 per cent girls reach Class XII, the emphasis should be on basic educational facilities," says Asif Khan, a lecturer at Kaiser College.

Despite criticism from various sections, the DF Government is still falling back on these populist schemes to

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year's budget. "There is a palpable anger among the minorities. But once money reaches them, their anger will die down," says Anees Ahmed, minister of minorities' development in the Ashok Chavan Cabinet.

This season of sops is especially aimed at the Muslims, who account for more than 13 per cent of the state's population. It's also because the Muslims in recent times have openly expressed their unhappiness with the government. Their grouse is the poor representation of the community in ticket distribution, as was evident dur-

cold storage for years. "This secular Government hasn't moved on these requests for a decade now," says Siddiqui. In Muslim-dominated Malegaon, the lack of higher education facilities and medical infrastructure continues. "The Government had promised a 15-point programme to implement the Sachar panel's recommendations but nothing happened," says Ismail.

Some community activists, however, aren't too pleased because going by the past record, most believe these schemes will remain only on paper. In

help it win over the disillusioned minorities in the state. "It's a regular poll-time strategy. The Government always wakes up just before the polls and then goes back to sleep again," says Rais Shaikh, general secretary of Qaumi Majlis-e-Shura, a social organisation working for minority welfare.

But will appeasing the minority communities help the DF Government win a clear majority in the assembly polls? With the elections a few months away, it won't be too long before the Government gets to know the efficacy of these schemes. ■